

**Pedestrian Advisory Committee Minutes of
March 9, 2022**

Meeting held remotely via Zoom, 7pm – 9pm

Members Present: David Trevvett (Chair), Marissa Vogt, Kerri Ann Tester, Anita Johnson, John Shreffler

Others Present: Shonali Gaudino (Transportation Board liaison), John Bowman (Bicycle Advisory Committee), Wendy Friedman (Transportation Board, representing Safe Routes to School at this meeting), Abby Swaine

Meeting Convened at 7:03 PM

Public Comment For Issues Not On the Agenda:

None

Approval of Minutes of February 23, 2022 Meeting:

The minutes were approved by a roll call vote with 4 members in favor. One member (Marissa Vogt) abstained as not present for the meeting in question.

Anita Johnson joined the meeting at 7:06pm.

Developing A Walkable Streets Plan For Brookline

David introduced the subject by noting that it will proceed in three parts. What do we want to say, how should the document be organized, and possible assignments for work on different parts. We'll be working on this plan for the next several meetings.

David noted that he didn't know exactly what the document should be so he wrote up something preliminary to induce discussion. Janice had suggested the need for a vision and a plan to implement it. David then elaborated a list of possible other items and approaches and then opened the subject for discussion.

Anita noted that the Town has to be hospitable to pedestrians. Wants to focus on the pedestrian experience, focusing on pedestrian comfort and safety. Kerri Ann wants to draw on existing Town documents and efforts supporting our efforts. Shonali wants to move the list of those measures included in the document to an appendix referred to in body of text. David asked if Section Two, listing the various ways in which pedestrians aren't well served should be in an appendix? Shonali noted that lots of these are opinions until backed by data. Could be reformatted into new sections with supporting data.

David then noted comments sent by John Bowman. Priorities could include making intersections safer (no turn on red, camera based enforcement, raised intersections and crosswalks, making sure that driveways don't slope down), traffic calming with sections where auto speed kept down to 20 MPH or less, eliminate sidewalk obstructions. For low hanging fruit, he suggests eliminating right turn on red throughout the Town. He also mentioned that if the Town committed to Slow Streets, then pedestrians could walk on the streets and the Town could assume responsibility for clearing sidewalks in the Green Routes Protected Network. Also suggests that for any street included under Complete Streets Program, the Town should commit to eliminating sidewalk obstructions. David likes the idea of removing light poles and mail boxes. David also noted that streets need to be engineered for slower speeds, which fits John's comment that Complete Streets should assess desirable speed limits and incorporate traffic calming measures to eliminate need for enforcement. Kerri Ann noted that she thinks that No Right Turn On Red Town wide will be a hard sell and depends on enforcement, which is sporadic where it's currently in place. John Shreffler noted that this is density related and not Townwide. In North Brookline drivers largely obey the prohibition. Kerri Ann notes that enforcement is difficult in the denser areas where it's most needed. Anita notes that other cities have enacted such bans. She also noted that pedestrians often don't wait for walk signals. Kerri Ann noted that many do, the discussion evolved into one on exclusive pedestrian intersections. David noted that the lighter used intersections such as Pleasant and Freeman often have pedestrians not waiting while at more heavily used ones (School/Aspinwall-Harvard) they do wait.

John Bowman noted that we should be bold and not settle for just what you think you can get, as this can be used against you the Plan implies that something less is all that you need. David agrees. Kerri Ann expressed reservations. David noted that the Town Meeting model structurally precludes possibilities for compromise but suggests we find ways to circumvent this. Kerri Ann queried our role, expressing the need for very strong advocacy using a reach bargaining strategy. David wants strong and well founded advocacy, noting that our recommendations are based on lots of experience and observations. Marissa noted that sidewalks outside commercial areas are often too narrow and wondered whether in quiet residential areas public space used for parking or waiting for two way traffic might be used to widen them. Perhaps move street trees into street. Possibly close streets for activities. David and Kerri Ann noted that the latter has happened on Beals Street for Halloween and has been suggested for School Street. Shonali would love to see public way used for pedestrians either by widening sidewalks or by closing them for pedestrian uses either permanently or for specific uses and/or days. Noted lack

of personal outdoor space for many. She noted the use of streets for basketball in her neighborhood and Kerri Ann said she had noted the same and that drivers slowed down as a result.

Marissa reminded the Committee about DPW's consultant assessment survey that had been completed the previous year on Brookline's roadway and sidewalk conditions, and said that she had never seen a summary from that study on sidewalk conditions. David showed last year's Pavement Management summary with no mention of sidewalks. Shonali noted need for addition of sidewalks into DPW Pavement Management Summary. Our Committee should request the sidewalk condition details from the study. He will inquire about those. John Bowman added that the Pavement Management System and studies are intended to prioritize road repairs and wonders why there isn't something similar for sidewalks. David responded that he's been told by DPW that the Pavement Management study did include sidewalks and that our Committee would have access to the results. DPW held Town Halls last year and did mention sidewalks and curb ramps so he expects that such data was collected. He'll inquire. Anita said that some have called for the reduction or elimination of parked cars but such actually protect pedestrians. David noted that the ideas are all valid but it's a tough balance. He intends to rewrite the document using the suggestions raised. He'll revise for April meeting. Kerri Ann noted that Wendy Friedman is representing Safe Routes to Schools (SRTS) tonight so should be allowed to comment on Part One. Wendy described the interaction between Safe Routes to Schools and the Bicycle Advisory Committee on the Green Routes. She hadn't received the document that David submitted but David noted that DPW hadn't uploaded it to the Town website. Wendy liked our discussion as she heard it. David noted that Safe Routes to Schools had written a section for the Bicycle Advisory Committee's Green Routes Plan with specific examples for each school and would like a similar section for our document. Wendy and Kerri Ann agreed to provide such. Wendy then discussed the procedures Safe Routes followed. They essentially provided an audit for each school and already had identified some suggestions for pedestrians. A discussion ensued as to timing, with David noting that we intend to have a firmer working document by April and would like the SRTS input by the May meeting, and Wendy thought this possible. John Bowman thought that the document could focus on destinations beyond schools such as parks and specific commercial districts, with similar writeups for each.

David then shifted the discussion to structuring the document. He plans to reduce initial materials and get into main thread, moving much (such as detailed lists) to appendices. He would like the document to go beyond text and wants other items

such as photos and tables. Shonali noted that Table A is the meat of what we're trying to say and can be fleshed out. She'd be happy to help with formatting or maps and so forth. David inquired what the Committee thought about the general principles. Kerri Ann wants the principles to have links to appendices, to cite sources. WHO's Age Friendly Cities checklist has a huge section on walkability for instance. We should collect the various pedestrian friendly Town statements to back this up. John Bowman re tables of treatments wants to differentiate by regions as commercial areas are distinct from residential areas. David notes that this is partly density but agrees that there are somethings that are universally true and others that depend on location. Shonali wants to include climate change and diversity. David noted that we have discussed both in other documents and can include them somewhere if not in principles. John S. noted that walking has the least amount of carbon capture of the various modes of transit. David wants to discuss the document with Todd Kirrane to see how Todd and DPW see the document and what they need or find useful. Wendy wants to emphasize interaction and quality of life. She particularly wants to emphasize interactions in commercial areas. Also the importance of walkable schools. She then discussed residential areas and their differences due to density. Should identify values for each zone. Kerri Ann agreed. David noted that Janice Morris had found an organization walkfriendly.org and he's very taken with the Walk Friendly concept. He noted that walkability is one of Brookline's strong points, especially for parents of school children. Wendy would like appendix re elements of pedestrian accommodations. David agrees and has acquired a list of linkable Town and Regional policies and guidelines. Anita queried if Fire Department objected to raised road elements. David said yes but noted that Somerville has apparently gotten their Fire Department on board with such. Anita noted a recent pedestrian auto accident on Babcock. David has seen no police report. Kerri Ann noted that you have to go to the Police HQ and request one and described procedures. She also noted that the Brookline Tab has stopped publishing Police Report Summaries. Anita will follow through and inquire. Discussion ensued as to Committee role with David emphasizing our advisory function to Transportation Board. Kerri Ann suggested possibly memorializing pedestrian accidents the way White Bikes memorialize bicycle accidents. John Bowman asked about Washington Street accident re turns. Wants raised crosswalks across side streets going into residential neighborhoods and possible narrowing the entrance to slow vehicle speeds.

David wonders about a possible vision statement, and discussed what such would entail. He described that as part of proposing a new student system at the University of Chicago someone from Student Services wrote a description tracing a student's interaction with the proposed technology during the day. He wants

Committee members to contribute. Kerri Ann volunteered to write such a section. David wants to present crash data re crashes involving pedestrians. Len Wholey has Police Department contacts. On other areas he wants volunteers. He then noted need for review of local and state guidelines for possible inclusion and need for review of our recommendations to the Transportation Board in Appendix A, to see if we need to pull some into document. He noted that time is short, noting the impact of Town Meeting in late May. David likes the idea of emphasizing the kind of Town Brookline is re walkability. David noted upcoming Warrant Articles including one he's submitting re Pedestrian Friendly Lighting. Abby volunteered to bird dog accessibility issues. David noted that immunocompromised folk are scared to go out post Covid, creating a new segment of disability.

Vacancy on Committee. David noted that Marianne Lee has resigned from the Committee and summarized the replacement process. He would like to use the process to expand our community so as to create a pool of volunteers. He wants to create a Committee subgroup to screen the applicants, then invite selected applicant to visit Committee meetings, the interview and votes. Kerri Ann wants to send something to Marianne like the flowers we sent to Christine. Abby proposed that we create a group of recently retired volunteers who might be looking for limited engagements. Organization would be a challenge and communication is a problem. Neighborhood Alliances or the Senior Center might be possible venues. Discussion of volunteer organization followed. Possible addition of language in Vacancy Announcement that the Committee is also looking for posse/acolytes for limited volunteer activities was discussed. Transportation Board Warrant Article on Vision Zero was discussed. David summarized the Transportation Board hearing on the Vision Zero Warrant Article.

Committee Housekeeping. David noted that our Committee has four Town Meeting Members so Town Meeting will impact on our bandwidth. John S. noted that Town Meeting will go 6-8 nights so our Committee will need to reschedule our June meeting for after June 15, which is a hard deadline for concluding Town Meeting. A discussion ensued re scheduling, settling on possible meeting on third Monday in June. Abby noted upcoming hearing on DPW budget. She also noted that at the recent Disability Commission hearing, they announced creation of a path from Beaconsfield T Stop under Dean Road to Beaconsfield. David noted that the upcoming DPW budget hearing is before Capital Subcommittee of Advisory Committee on March 16. He then noted that a complaint has been filed about audible pedestrian signals at Davis and Cypress. Town has adjusted volume down but complaining continues. The signal is on recall but presumably pedestrians persist in pushing the button, activating audible signal.

Meeting adjourned at 9:05.

Minutes prepared by John Shreffler